



floAt's Mobile Agent

Here's a really addictive software for all the Sony Ericsson fans out there

Robert Sovereign-Smith

In the past, in this same section, we've spoken about phone managers. Admittedly, most people have Nokia phones, and most phone managers are therefore targeted towards those models. However, with the growing popularity of other brands, and some very nice models being released, it's time to look at something else.

floAt's Mobile Agent (fMA) is an option everyone with a Sony Ericsson phone should consider. It's an open source project, started by—arguably—the biggest Sony Ericsson fans around. In what follows, we'll show you how to install and start using this advanced phone manager.

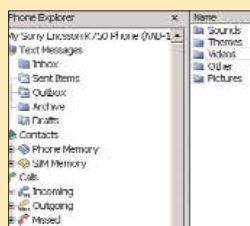
01 : 00 Getting Started

Before anything else, head over to <http://snipurl.com/v9hr> and look for your phone model number, and confirm that the stable release of fMA supports it. Though this software is designed for Sony Ericsson phones, it also works with some models of other brands.

Next, install the software from this month's Digit CD.

05 : 00 Connecting

You will need to install your phone's drivers on your PC and connect your phone via either Bluetooth or USB. With this done, launch fMA and go to **Phone > Connect**, or press [F7]. fMA will connect to the phone and get a list of all the contacts, messages and data on your phone. It will then ask you to sync times between your phone and computer, which



Browsing the contents of a phone is a snap

to arrive at correct decisions about which file version is newer.

10 : 00 The Interface

No problems here; fMA is designed to look like a cross between Windows Explorer and Microsoft Outlook—the folder navigation is Explorer-style, while contact and event handling will make MS Office users feel right at home. Take a look at all the menu options and you'll find they're all self-explanatory. On the left, you'll see the folder structure, and on the right you'll see details including call history, messages, battery status, and even signal strength.

12 : 00 The Basics

Once you start using fMA, you'll find yourself more addicted to it each day. At least when you're sitting at your computer, you're likely to never touch your phone—and you don't need to.

If you want to shoot off an SMS to someone, just press [Ctrl] + [N]. Type in your text, choose a recipient, and click Send—it really is that simple. The same goes for making or receiving a call—just press [Ctrl] + [Shift] + [C], or go to **Action > Call Contact**, choose a contact, and click Call.

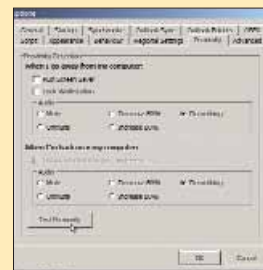
you should do. This step is more important than you might think, because any two devices that exchange data should have the same date and time

15 : 00 Expert Stuff

The developers of fMA seem to have taken note of the fact that a lot of us are absent-minded. Using fMA, you can make sure that as soon as you step out of Bluetooth range, your computer automatically locks itself. You

can also set it to mute sounds or reduce the system volume, and reset itself when you return. Go to **Tools > Options**, click on the

Proximity tab, and change the settings there.



Decide what your computer does when you move away from it

25 : 00 Irritants

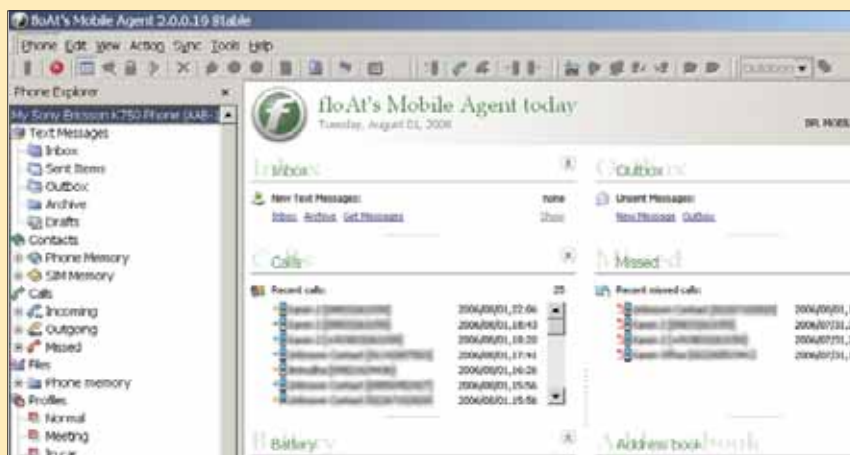
No software is perfect, and by now you will have found a fair share of bugs in fMA. For instance, we used it in conjunction with a Sony Ericsson K750i on an AMD Athlon 64 3000+, MSI RS480 MII motherboard with 1 GB of DDR 400 RAM, and found that very often it would hang, and start consuming 99 per cent CPU. If this happens to you, the only way out is to open the Task Manager ([Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Delete]) and end-task MobileAgent.exe.

Another thing that will have you tearing your hair out is when you try and type a new SMS using fMA. The window that pops up tries to use a transparency effect but fails miserably. The first thing you're going to want to do is get rid of that transparent look by heading over to **Tools > Options** and clicking on the Appearance tab. Here, you will see various values at the bottom. It's best to change everything to 255 (solid), so you can see what you're typing.

And You're Done!

Most of what you'll see in fMA doesn't need much explanation, and you should have no trouble getting by. Our thanks to the floAt's Mobile Agent developers for keeping this open source. If you're a developer, you will find that it's really easy to make scripts work with fMA, so go ahead and add some functionality to the project! ☑

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The fMA interface is neat and clean, and easy to navigate